

MERT KOBAS

New York University, Department of Psychology
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CURRENT POSITION

Rutgers University, Newark, United States Postdoctoral Associate (incoming), Department of Psychology	09.2026
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EDUCATION

New York University, New York, United States Ph.D. in Cognition & Perception, GPA: 3.89/4.00	09.2021 – 05.2026
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Koç University, İstanbul, Turkey M.A. in Developmental Psychology GPA: 3.89/4.00	09.2018 – 08.2021
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Boğaziçi University, İstanbul, Turkey B.A in Guidance and Psychological Counseling under Educational Sciences Graduated with honors GPA: 3.43/4.00	09.2012 – 07.2018
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Radboud University, Nijmegen, The Netherlands Student in Psychology Department, Erasmus Plus Program	08.2016 – 01.2017
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PUBLICATIONS

Peer Reviewed Articles

- Kobaş, M.**, Demir-Lira, Ö., Akman, İ., & Göksun, T. (2025). Spatial Language Development in Preterm and Full-Term Infants: The Role of Object Exploration and Parents' Spatial Input. *Journal of Experimental Child Psychology*, 256, 106264.
- Horne, Z., **Kobaş, M.**, & Cimpian, A. (2025). Historical and experimental evidence that inherent properties are overweighted in early scientific explanation. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 122 (38), e2424725122.
- Doğan, I., Kızıldere, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, Ö. E., Akman, İ., & Göksun, T. (2025). Early parental multimodal input is differentially associated with later vocabulary knowledge for preterm and full-term infants. *Language Learning and Development*, 1-27.
- Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Doğan, I., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, Ö., Akman, İ., & Göksun, T. (2023). Motor skills, language development, and visual processing in preterm and full-term infants. *Current Psychology*, 1-13.

Turan, E., **Kobaş, M.**, & Göksun, T. (2021). Spatial Language and Mental Transformation in Preschoolers: Does Relational Reasoning Matter? *Cognitive Development*, 57, 100980.

Kobaş, M., Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2021). Fine Motor Abilities and Parental Input of Spatial Features Predict Object Word Comprehension of Turkish-Learning Children. *Infant and Child Development*, 30(4), e2243.

Schoenegger, P., Salvi, F., Liu, J., Nan, X., Debnath, R., Fasolo, B., Leivada, E., Recchia, G., Günther, F., Zarifhonorvar, A., Kwon, J., Islam, Z. U., Dehnert, M., Lee, D. Y. H., Reinecke, M. G., Kamper, D. G., **Kobaş, M.**, Sandford, A., Kgombo, J., ... Karger, E. (under review). Large Language Models Are More Persuasive Than Incentivized Human Persuaders.

Peer Reviewed Conference Proceedings

Ateş, T., Ateşoğlu, Ş., Yiğit, Ç., Kesen, İ., **Kobaş, M.**, Erdem, E., Erdem, A., Göksun, T., & Yüret, D. (2022). CRAFT: A Benchmark for Causal Reasoning About Forces and interactions. 60th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics.

Ateş, T., Ateşoğlu, Ş., Yiğit, Ç., Kesen, İ., **Kobaş, M.**, Erdem, E., Erdem, A., Göksun, T., & Yüret, D. (2020). CRAFT: A Benchmark for Causal Reasoning About Forces and interactions. NeurIPS Shared Visual Representations in Human & Machine Intelligence Workshop.

Manuscripts under preparation

Kobaş, M., & Cimpian, A. (in preparation). Reconciling two competing views on the process of generating explanations: Rational inference vs. intuitive biases.

Kobaş, M., Yılmaz, B., & Göksun, T. (in preparation). The relationship between vocabulary and executive function skills in preterm and full-term toddlers.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Kobaş, M., & Cimpian, A. (2026, April). Reconciling two competing views on the process of generating explanations: Rational inference vs. intuitive biases. Talk presented at the Cognitive Development Society (CDS) 2026 Biennial Conference, Montreal, Canada.

Kobaş, M., & Cimpian, A. (2025, May). Reconciling two competing views on the process of generating explanations: Rational inference vs. intuitive biases. Poster presented at the Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) 2025 Biennial Meeting, Minneapolis, MN.

Kobaş, M., Horne, Z., & Cimpian, A. (2023, July). The Inherence Bias in Scientific Explanations. Poster presented at 1st Minds, Brains, and Machine Summer Poster Conference, New York, NY.

Kobaş, M., Tworek, C. M., & Cimpian, A. (2023, July). Expertise mitigates the inherence bias in everyday explanations. Poster presented at 45th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, CogSci 2023, Sydney, Australia.

Kobaş, M., Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Fine Motor Abilities and Parental Input of Object Dimensions Predict Receptive Language. Poster presented at the 15th International Association for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.

- Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Doğan, I., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Fine Motor Abilities, Visual Perception, and Language Development in Preterm and Term Infants. Poster presented at the 15th International Association for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Kızıldere, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Doğan, I., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Event Representation, Parental Spatial Input, and Relational Language Comprehension in Full-Term and Preterm Infants. Paper Presented in Demir-Lira (chair), Beyond Quantity-Quality: Specifying Aspects of High-Quality Parental Language Input that Predict Optimal Child Outcomes. International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Doğan, I., **Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Parental Verbal Input in Different Gestational Weeks and Atypical Development. Poster Presented at the International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Turan, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Turkish children's learning of postpositions: The role of spatial representations. Poster Presented at the International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Kobaş, M.**, & Göksun, T. (2021, June). Early Walking Leads to Changes in Parents' Spatial Input. Poster presented at the Development in Motion Conference (Virtual Conference).
- Kızıldere, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Doğan, I., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., Akman, İ. & Göksun, T. (2021, April). Parents' spatial language scaffolds pre-and full-term infants' mental rotation skills. Poster presented at Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) Biennial Meeting (Virtual Symposium).
- Doğan, I., **Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., Akman, İ. & Göksun, T. (2021, April). Parents' gestural but not verbal input associates with word comprehension in pre-and full-term infants. Poster presented at Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) Biennial Meeting (Virtual Symposium).
- Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A. & Göksun, T. (2021, January). Fine Motor Abilities, Visual Perception and Executive Functions in Preterm and Full-Term Infants. Poster presented at the 11th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.
- Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Doğan, I., & Göksun, T. (2020, January). Gross Motor Abilities, Visual Perception, and Language Development in Preterm and Term Infants. Poster presented at the 10th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.
- Turan, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Altunay, H., Esmer, Ş., Erkekli, E., & Göksun, T. (2020, January). The Effects of Relational Language on Children's Spatial Cognition. Poster presented at the 10th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.

HONORS & AWARDS

Taith Research Visit Grant

2026

- Awarded by Taith, the Welsh Government's international learning exchange programme, to support a research visit to the Cardiff University Babylab hosted by Dr. Hana D'Souza and Dr. Dean D'Souza.

Cognitive Development Society Diversity Travel Award

2026

- Awarded by Cognitive Development Society to support travel, conference registration and presentation at Cognitive Development Society 2026 Conference in Montreal, Canada

NYU GSAS Dean's Travel Grant

Spring 2025 & Fall 2025

- Awarded by the NYU GSAS Dean to support travel and presentation at a scholarly conference

MacCracken Fellowship

2021 - 2026

- Multi-year doctoral fellowship from NYU GSAS providing full tuition, health insurance, and stipend support for Ph.D. studies.

Academic Excellence Award, Koç University

2021

- One-time graduation honor awarded to graduate students for exceptional academic achievement at Koç University, Turkey.

Fee Waivers for BCCCD 2021, 2020, & 2018

2021 & 2020

- 11th and 10th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development

Boğaziçi University *cum laude*

2018

Ministry of National Education Scholarship

2012–2017

- National award granted by the Ministry of National Education to only 5,000 top students admitted to education programs across Turkey.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Rutgers University, Mc² Lab, New Jersey

Asst. Prof. Kimele Persaud

- Literature review, study conceptualization and experimental design for a line of research investigating how prior knowledge and surprise support young children's memory and learning
- Stimuli development, task design and piloting for studies examining children's memory for expectation-congruent and expectation-violating events
- Conceptual and methodological contributions to empirical and computational approaches examining the cognitive capacities and task features that shape expectation-driven learning in early childhood

New York University, Cognitive Development Laboratory, New York

Prof. Andrei Cimpian

- Experimental task design, data analysis, participant recruitment, data visualization, and conceptualization of a study investigating the theories about how people generate explanations
- Survey design, participant recruitment, data analysis, data visualization, and conceptualization of a study investigating scientific explanations
- Survey data analysis, and conceptualization of a study investigating the relation between expertise and cognitive biases

Koç University Language and Cognition Laboratory, İstanbul

Prof. Tilbe Gökşun

- Data analysis and project management from preschoolers for the study investigating the relationship between spatial abilities and relational language
- Experimental task design, survey design, data analysis, participant recruitment, coding and collection for the study investigating longitudinal relationship between event representation, language development & motor abilities in infants and children
- Experimental task design, survey design, data collection and conceptual support for a machine learning project related to intuitive physics

Educational Sciences at Boğaziçi University, İstanbul

Asst. Prof. Nihal Yeniad

- Contributed to literature search & project organization on attention, well-being and parent-child interaction.

Koç University Independent Evaluation Laboratory, İstanbul

Asst. Prof. Yasemin Kisbu Sakarya

- Chosen under the Koç University Summer Research Program, helped data collection from adults on the brief psychosocial intervention and assisted report for intervention evaluation.

Meta-Analysis Study, Educational Sciences at Boğaziçi University, İstanbul

Asst. Prof. Nihal Yeniad (collaboration with Dr. Michael Sulik from NYU)

- Contributed to literature search on executive functions, depression and well-being.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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| • Instructor, Statistics for the Behavioral Sciences
(PSYCH-UA.10) | Summer 2026 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Spring 2026 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Fall 2025 |
| • Instructor, Statistics for the Behavioral Sciences
(PSYCH-UA.10) | Summer 2025 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Spring 2025 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Dr. Aspen Yoo) | Fall 2024 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Spring 2024 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Research Methods in Psychology
(Psyc 301; Prof. Tilbe Göksun) | Spring 2020 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Lifespan Development
(Psyc 206; Prof. Tilbe Göksun) | Fall 2019 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Cognitive Development
(Psyc 445; Prof. Tilbe Göksun) | Spring 2019 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Issues in Psychology
(Psyc 210; Prof. Fuat Balci) | Fall 2018 |

UNDERGRADUATE & GRADUATE MENTORING

Madelyn Zamelis (2025 - 2026)
Ariella Pevzner (2024 – 2026)
Stephanie Yandun* (2024 – 2025)
Maya Rabago (2023 – 2025)
Emma Baxendale (2023-2024, M.A. Student)
Olivia Duan** (2023 – 2026, NYU Dean's Undergraduate Research Fund recipient,
Coons/Leibowitz Award for Honors Research recipient)
Vidisha Goyal *** (2021 – 2022)
Taygun Yorulmaz (2020-2021)
Elif Erkekli (2019-2021, Koç University Summer Research Program)
Mahmut Kurupınar (2019-2020, Koç University Summer Research Program)
Gülfem Sarı (2019-2020, Koç University Summer Research Program)

- * Student mentee presented research project at the NYU 2nd Annual DreamMakers Summit
- ** Student mentee presented research project at the NYU Undergraduate Research Conference,
- *** Student mentee presented a research project and was awarded best poster at the NYU Undergraduate Research Conference

Professional Service

Conference Reviewing

- NeurIPS 2022 Shared Visual Representations in Human & Machine Intelligence (SVRHM)
- 13th Budapest Central European University Conference on Cognitive Development
- The ACM Symposium on Virtual Reality Software and Technology (VRST) 2025

Co-reviewing

- Infant and Child Development
- Child Development

Moderation

- PsyArXiv

SKILLS

Languages

- Turkish, English, German

Computer

- R, Python, SPSS, JASP, Jamovi
- Elan, Datavyu, Octoparse, Qualtrics, Maxqda
- Microsoft Office, Adobe Illustrator, Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Premier, Logic Pro